Given strained center-periphery relations, ruling Kabul was often an end in itself. Such was the case during Amanullah Khan's reign in the 1920s, Zahir Shah's reign afterwards, that of Daud Khan in the 1970s, the communists in 1980, the Taliban in 1990s, as well as Hamid Karzai and Ashraf Ghani in the 2000s. What kept Karmal and Najibullah in power, apart from Soviet support, was their capacity to run a well-oiled patronage network.[118] Soviet rubles ensured that the Parchamis bought allegiance of different Afghan factions when, in reality, no such support existed on ideological, ethnic, or tribal lines. Karmal, in his initial years did exactly that and expanded his government with representatives from outside the PDPA.[119] Surrounded by a sundry group of loyalists, however, the Parchami core had multiple layers of enemies as well. The Khalqis were the first in line, especially Gulabzoi, Watanjar, and Sarwari. Other prominent Khalqi opponents included Nazar Mohammad and Shahnawaz Tanai, both senior generals in the Afghan army with loyalty to the Khalq. Representing a threat from within the government, and having some support in Moscow, these enemies were the most dangerous. They could be co-opted financially or appointed to faraway embassies. They could also be put behind bars. The Mujahideen formed the second layer of enemies.

Given the nature of both domestic Afghan and global Cold War politics, India had to choose how to deal with the Kabul government. Pakistan, for instance, despite having diplomatic relations with Afghanistan, fought the Kabul government. India had the option to deal solely with the Parcham leadership, or develop a genuinely non-aligned (or multi-aligned) approach in which it would engage with all Afghan political outfits and accept whomsoever came to power in Kabul. By siding with Moscow, however, the Indian leadership had severely limited the scope of its Afghanistan policy. If it engaged with the Mujahideen it would undermine its relations not just with the PDPA but also with the Soviet Union. Unlike the pre-1979 Afghanistan where Indian diplomats were welcomed by everyone and welcomed everyone in return, the post-1979 Afghanistan was a much more complicated place. Two cases of India's engagement with Afghanistan in the 1980s, however, highlight its pro-Parcham bias. The first case was Gandhi's close links with Karmal. Politically moderate (relative to other communist leaders) and representing an urban intellectual Marxist elite, Karmal was not